

How Patch Journalists Can Use ChatGPT To Turn Town Meetings Into News Stories

A practical step-by-step workflow for covering local government meetings using ChatGPT, transcription tools, and Associated Press-style prompts.

What Kind of Meetings Are We Talking About?

The resident volunteers on Boards of Selectmen, Planning & Zoning, Finance, Education, Inland Wetlands, Zoning Appeals and other commissions and committees meet regularly to hash out matters that often keenly affect your readership.

Why Write an Article on Your Town's Municipal Meetings?

...after all, these have not exactly proven to be pageview magnets.

But on the crucially important upside, these articles help to establish Patch as the “expert” in local politics. As SEO becomes increasingly supplanted by GEO (Generative Engine Optimization), LLMs reward the “perceived authority” of a news outlet with superior, if not exclusive, link placement in their responses.

You want to see a link to your work alongside those “AI Overviews” dished out by Google’s latest version of its search engine results, or cited by LLMs such as ChatGPT when someone asks about local news matters? You need to convince them you are the go-to expert in your town’s local news. The surest way to accomplish that is to provide important news that your competition is overlooking, on a regular basis.

Typically, an editor running several Patches wouldn’t have the time to go this deep in their local reporting, either, but AI makes it possible. And... editors may tag any municipal meeting stories as “Patch Exclusives.”

Workflow 1: Meeting Minutes → News Article

Step 1: Get the Meeting Minutes

Download or copy the official meeting minutes from the town website.

For some towns, you can sign up on their website to receive a free copy of a meeting's minutes and agendas (usually as PDFs or MS Word docs) via email.

Step 2: Open ChatGPT

Start a new chat in ChatGPT.

Step 3: Paste the Prompt

Copy and paste the following prompt into ChatGPT:

None

Rewrite these [DATE] meeting minutes of the [TOWN], [STATE] [MUNICIPAL BODY] as a news article in the neutral style of an Associated Press journalist.

Requirements:

Lead with the most newsworthy actions or votes.

Attribute comments clearly.

Summarize discussion concisely.

Include vote counts when available.

Do not editorialize or speculate.

Write for a hyperlocal readership in [TOWN], [STATE].

Then generate:

An SEO-friendly headline (≤109 characters)

A meta description (≤136 characters)

Meeting minutes:

[PASTE TEXT HERE, or attach to prompt]

Step 4: Attach or Paste the Minutes

You can either paste the full text directly into the prompt, or upload the minutes file as an attachment.

Step 5: Review the Draft Carefully

Paste ChatGPT's work into the Patch CMS. Before publishing:

- Verify vote counts
- Confirm names and titles
- Check quotes against the original minutes
- Make sure the lede reflects the most important action
- Remove anything that sounds promotional or speculative

Step 6: Publish

Once checked and carefully amended as necessary, you can often use the content as-generated, but pageview-rewarding tweaks to the hed, lede and meta description are usually obvious and simple, and quick pull-quotes make them all yours (e.g., 'This Is Not Going To Get Easy': Ridgefield Leaders Wrangle Over Budget Cut Demands')

These municipal meeting articles also lend themselves keenly to recirc links. Depending on the article's length, consider adding 2-3 links to your work on the previous meeting from this commission, or your story on the budget referendum results that influenced discussions in the current meeting, etc.

The Agenda Variation

In a classic 2-for1 play, you can often squeeze a story from a committee's published agenda. Purge the above prompt of all "requirements" except **Write for a hyperlocal readership in [TOWN], [STATE], and change these [DATE] meeting minutes to this [DATE] meeting agenda.** The AI will create a forward-looking promo for the meeting, which you may consider scheduling to publish the day before or even day of the meeting, with an appropriately urgent hed.

Workflow 2: Meeting Transcript → News Article

Use this workflow when you have meeting audio or video and no transcript — or even if you have a transcript, as the results from this workflow are invariably superior to working only from minutes.

Step 1: Obtain the Meeting Recording

Look for livestream recordings, YouTube uploads, Zoom recordings, MP3 audio files, MP4 video files. Your town may host these on its website, or provide links to third-party providers.

Step 2: Create a Transcript

Option A: Upload Directly to a Transcription Service

If you have a standalone audio/video file:

1. Upload it to [Otter.ai](#), [TurboScribe](#), or another transcription service
2. Wait for transcription to complete

Option B: Record Playback Into Otter.ai

If the meeting is exclusively available on your town's website

1. Open the meeting on your laptop
2. Open Otter.ai
3. Play the meeting audio aloud
4. Let Otter.ai record and transcribe in real time

Step 3: Export the Transcript

Export as plain text (`.txt`) preferred. This format works best with ChatGPT.

Step 4: Open ChatGPT

Start a new chat.

Step 5: Upload the Transcript and Paste the Prompt

Use the following prompt:

None

Rewrite this transcript of the [DATE] meeting of the [TOWN], [STATE] [MUNICIPAL BODY] as a news article in the neutral style of an Associated Press journalist.

Requirements:

Identify speakers by name and title when possible.

Remove filler, repetition and off-topic remarks.

Highlight decisions, disagreements and next steps.

Preserve exact meaning of quotes.

Do not invent attribution.

Write for a hyperlocal readership in [TOWN], [STATE].

Then generate:

1) An SEO-friendly headline (≤109 characters)

2) A meta description (≤136 characters)

Attach the transcript file to the prompt.

Step 6: Fact-Check the Draft

Paste ChatGPT's work into the Patch CMS. Always verify:

- Names and titles
- Vote counts
- Quotes
- Timeline of decisions
- Motions and outcomes

AI can miss context or confuse speakers during complicated discussions.

Step 7: Add Context Before Publishing

Good local government stories often need prior meeting history, budget context, links to applications or agenda packets, previous controversies, and public reaction which can often be found during the “public comment” portions of meetings. This context may not appear in the transcript itself.

Tips for Better Results

Ask for Follow-Up Rewrites

You can ask ChatGPT:

- “Rewrite with a stronger lede”
- “Shorten this by 200 words”
- “Focus more on the budget vote”
- “Organize chronologically”
- “Highlight the major disagreements”

Upload Supporting Documents

Context and accuracy will be improved by attaching agendas, packets, presentations, proposed budgets and prior meeting minutes. Identify these in your prompt.

Important Editorial Reminder

ChatGPT is a reporting assistant — not a replacement for editorial judgment.

Always:

- verify facts
- review quotes
- confirm names
- read the original source material
- apply newsroom standards before publication

The final responsibility for accuracy remains with the journalist.